

not limiting our beliefs around what we can and can't achieve with money, and making sure our boundaries are present and correct. Make sure that you bring that progress with you into this step.

The omnipresent cycle, and how to break it

Emotional spending is cyclical, as with so much else about wellbeing and money. It can be hard to identify where it starts, or where we can intervene to try to redirect ourselves, but it's vital that we find a way to break those patterns of behaviour if we are hoping to develop a better relationship with money. My own journey towards control over my emotional spending habits has definitely had its ups and down, and a lot of the financial trouble I found myself in for the first decade or so of my adult life was triggered by my struggle to deal with my emotions in a healthy way, and dips in my mental health. At times when my anxiety levels have been running high, I've always reached for shopping as a release, a way to relieve some of the tension building in my brain. Similarly, when I was feeling low, or bored, or lonely, I would search for what was missing in my life and decide that whatever it was, I could probably plug the gap, at least temporarily, with a new dress or scatter cushion. It would work for a brief moment, giving me a hit of dopamine and something to look forward to. Posting pictures of the same 'it' products as everyone else on social media helped me to feel as if I was part of a club, which I found especially difficult to resist when dealing with the